



Women's activism as public relations in a patriarchal society: The case of Kuwait

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Activism
Public relations
Women's organization
Women's social and political rights
Kuwait
Middle East

ABSTRACT

This paper addresses an important era of women's activism in Kuwait. In the 1950s, when the government recognized women's rights for education, the wave to obtain other civil rights clashed with culture, tradition and religion which became serious obstacles facing women in their struggle for basic rights. This historical study focuses on the establishment of two women's organizations – the Arab Women's Development Society in December 1962 and the Kuwait Women's Cultural and Social Society in February 1963. To sway the negative image of women in a patriarchal society, women used activism as a public relations tool to achieve their social, civil and political rights. The study uses cultural-economic model (CEM) to illustrate how activism and public relations were articulated as synonymous to foster women's rights in Kuwait. Archived documents and content analysis of media content published in the 1960s reveal that activism played a vital role as a public relations strategy and that social activism was more effective than political activism. The study highlights the implications of culture within the context of both public relations and activism.

1. Background

When Kuwait was established as a Sheikhdom (*Mshikhat al-Kuwayt*) in the 17th century, women were not accorded equal rights as men. The historical perspective of the role of women in Kuwait was greatly influenced by the dominant male-oriented culture, traditions and religion in the country (Ghabra, 1997). The tide of women's rights and freedoms crested when activists started awareness movements to engage women in various governmental sectors such as education and health (Alazmi, 2014; Tirca, 2020). Education played a critical role to elevate status and power for women in Kuwaiti society. Not until the ruling of Sheikh Abdullah Al-Salem from 1950 to 1965 did education emerge as an attainable right for women in Kuwait. During his ruling, the number of female students enrolled at public schools increased exponentially from 1334 to 10,761 in 1958 and continued growing to reach 38,238 in 1965 (Baghdadi, 1994). Such support of women's rights in education under the ruling Emir (Sheikh Al-Salem) was not without its detractors. Public resistance expressed from the conservative element of society

forced the Joint Administrative Board (*Majlis Aledari Almushtarak*) to ban women from working anywhere in public sectors other than health and social affairs, a notion rejected by the Emir (Al-Rayis, 2014). Another concern in public discourse was that women would abandon Kuwaiti traditions as they started gaining access to education. As a result, parents in this patriarchal society were reluctant to send their daughters to study in foreign countries until 1957 when a few women began leaving Kuwait for obtaining education as part of girls' scientific missions. The first group to leave the country through such missions consisted of eight girls but reached 81 in 1961 and 293 in 1966 (Al-Mahmeed, 2007). However, few women from merchant families traveled, with their families or alone, to Cairo, Beirut, London or other Arab and Western cities until the early 1950s. Ironically, many of the women who traveled abroad later became activists demanding further social, civil and political rights (Al-Mahmeed, 2007; Shalaby, 2015).

This research examines two popular Kuwaiti women's organizations rooted in the 1960s using the five moments of the cultural-economic model (CEM) to analyze their activism geared toward influencing the

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Kuwaiti societal image of women and to improve their civil, social and political rights. The methods of activism were analyzed using a content analysis, which offers insights into the language and symbolism the organizations employed to achieve goals, express ideas, and mobilize support. The CEM framework concurrently reveals the public relations efforts of women's organizations and contextualizes the ways in which they challenged existing power structures embedded in Kuwaiti society, culture and religion. Such an approach provides a critical-cultural treatment to public relations and activism. To the authors' knowledge, there have been no previous studies examining women's activism or social movements with reference to public relations in the context of Kuwait and the Middle East. This research paper consequently advances a critical-cultural perspective of public relations through the analysis of women's activism practice in a Kuwaiti and illuminates activism and public relations in the broader backdrop of the Middle East.

2. History of women and education in Kuwait

The educational priority for women in Kuwait was initially to memorize the Holy Quran either by their guardian at home or by "*Al-Mutwaeah* or *Al-Mulayah*" (a female teacher) at Islamic schools called "*Kuttab*s or *Maktab*s" (Al-Kazi, 2011). In 1937–1938, the first government schools for girls opened, but girls were required to pay tuition to attend while boys attended for free. The first school for girls enrolled a class of 140 students (Meleis et al., 1979; Tirca, 2020). The discovery of oil in Kuwait and ensuring export boom sparked social developments in the country. As oil revenues poured in, so too did the increase in new schools and universities, along with a societal shift toward education abroad. After living under the burden of harsh customs and traditions toward women (Ahmed & Shekho, 2021), societal perceptions of women and equality loosened and led to modest improvements.

By 1945–1946 school year, there were four schools for girls (Bidwi, 2017). In the academic year 1955–54, teaching English started for 12 female students at Alqabliya School. According to the first official government report in 1957, 74 % of women were illiterate in comparison to 46 % of men at the age of 10 and beyond (Academia, 2023; Meleis et al., 1979). The founding of Kuwait University in 1966 emboldened more women to obtain a university degree domestically after education for women was previously limited to those families who could afford to send their daughters to study abroad.

One of the impacts of Kuwait's compulsory education policy mandated by the constitution of 1961 is that education for women became an obligatory right and was not subject to the will or preference of the family to enter female family members in education (Tétreault, 2001). Opportunities for women in education provided them a modicum of power and specialized skills to better compete with men. The Kuwaiti women who studied abroad returned home to join the activist groups that fought for women's rights in the country. Moreover, women who studied abroad brought back a new vision to gain social, civil, and political rights. They became more involved, not only in politics but also in other leadership positions that made them important contributors to the overall economic growth and stability of the country (Shalaby, 2015).

3. Women's organizations

Activism for women started in Kuwait in early 1950s but became more active in the 1960s when loosely structured groups of women became formalized through women's rights organizations. These organizations provided a space for women to express concerns and practice

social rights absent the male patriarchal gaze (Buscemi, 2016). The rise of formal women's rights organizations did not escape public criticism for being "anti-traditional, anti-Islamic, and anti-Kuwaiti, not to mention heretical and traitorous stalking horses for foreign imperialists" (Tétreault et al., 2012, p. 266). At the head of the rights movement for women were two landmark organizations: The Arab Women's Development Society (AWDS) and Women's Cultural and Social Society (WCSS).¹

In 1974, both organizations merged under the banner of the Kuwaiti Women's Union (KWU) while retaining their own identities. The KWU alliance only lasted for three years before dissolving, irrevocably splintered into conflicting agendas and visions among Kuwaiti women for Kuwaiti women, including whether to adopt a unified vision regarding Kuwaiti women's issues (Dianu, 2002). The sharp political divisions between the organizations led to the formation of yet another entity to escape the fray, the Girls Club (formed in 1976). In this regard Al-Mukaimi (2010, p. 54) wrote:

The women's movement was divided over the difference of demands between middle-class women who rushed to issue a petition demanding political rights in the early seventies and women of the merchant class who decided to wait a little until the Kuwaiti woman's maturation of political participation.

Women's groups as voluntary associations were controlled and funded by the Ministry of Social Affairs and Labor as stated in law No. 24 of 1962 concerning clubs and Non-profit organizations (Al-Mughni, 1996). These women's organizations were considered the only space for Kuwaiti women to engage in public sphere.

3.1. The Arab women's development society (AWDS)

In December 1962, middle class women led by Nouriya Al-Sadani,² established the *Arab Women's Development Society* (AWDS), formally starting the first organization for women in Kuwait (Al-Kazi, 2011; Olimat, 2009). Based on the organizational goals and operational vision, Rizzo (2005, pp 79–101) categorized AWDS as a *professional* organization concerned with women's political rights and social change that emphasized issues of gender equality by raising awareness of the plight of women in Kuwaiti society and Middle Eastern countries. Accordingly, the central purpose of AWDS was political, aiming to lead women to join a political party and engage with the parliament since the constitution guaranteed equal rights for both men and women. In practice, however, equality eluded women who could not vote by Electoral Law and were required to adhere to strict modesty in dress and social codes (Al-Mughni, 2001). AWDS also focused on modernizing society by raising the status of women (Al-Mughni, 2001; Al-Mukaimi, 2010; Olimat, 2009).

3.2. Women's cultural and social society (WCSS)

The formation of AWDS and its political aims through middle class women was at loggerheads with The Women's Cultural and Social Society (WCSS) that formed a year later. The establishment of a women's association under the name of the *Women's Cultural & Social Society* (WCSS)³ was officially recognized on February 10, 1963 (Intikhabi,

¹ The name of the organization was originally the Cultural and Social Society (CSS), but in 1966 The Ministry of Social Affairs and Labour demanded adding the word "women" to its title to avoid confusion with a men's organization with the same name. This background led to the Women's Cultural and Social Society (WCSS).

² The first female Kuwaiti TV director who studied TV directing in Cairo from 1964–1965.

³ First it was called Cultural and Social Society before it was renamed to Women's Cultural and Social Society.

2020). Based on organizational goals and operational vision, Rizzo (2005) categorized WCSS as a *service* organization relying on voluntary initiatives associated with welfare (charitable), education, health, and family. WCSS emerged primarily from merchant women activists with university-level education who envisioned the need for a non-profit organization as a start pointing to augment the women's movement (Alazmi, 2014; Olimat, 2009). The main objective of the organization was to raise the level of awareness of women regarding their inferior societal standing and to promote their participation in community activities. While WCSS provided entertainment for its members and charity to the poor, WCSS avoided addressing the women's rights that AWDS' embraced such as gender equality and women's citizenship (Al-Mughni, 1996).

An early issue for the WCSS was its deleterious societal perception as a liberal feminist organization considering its membership was largely comprised of liberals who ideologically clashed with other conservative organizations across Kuwait (Alazmi, 2014). WCSS provided recreational activities for its members, charity to help the poor, and support for Arab causes. Its membership was restricted only to the educated. Representing the merchant class, women in this organization wanted members with specific backgrounds, namely those from elite social groups, thus turning it into a class organization. In turn, this served to maintain the status quo of a prestige organization (Al-Mukaimi, 2010). WCSS practiced its activism through the work of several subcommittees in areas such as culture, social affairs, health, *Zakat* (Islamic taxation), nursery, media and after the liberation of Kuwait, through a new committee called "Follow-up Committee on Prisoners and Missing Persons" (Al-Hajji, 2000). According to Mrs. Lulwa Almulla, current president of WCSS, the organization started its movement through social activities to empower women and make them aware of their rights and the importance of their well-being, in addition to educational programs to combat illiteracy (Ebrahim, 2019). Mrs. Almulla identified five strategic initiatives for WCSS in its early stages: (1) encourage women to participate in volunteer work, (2) encourage women to adopt a problem-solving mindset to social issues, (3) allocate classrooms to eradicate female illiteracy, (4) establish the first nursery in Kuwait to help women raise their children, and to (5) encourage women to abandon traditional home boundaries to work (Alaslan & Jamal, 2011). WCSS was careful to complement the issues AWDS addressed such as gender equality and women's citizenship rights (Al-Mughni, 1996).

4. Activism and public relations

For the last decade, activism has gained a foothold in public relations practice, with researchers calling for critical research to understand the role of theory in activism and public relations (Adi, 2018; Ciszek, 2015; Curtin, 2016; Dozier & Lauzen, 2000; Gudkova and Sarikakis, 2018; L'Etang, 2016). Many of the tactics and motives used in social reform by activists are considered today as part of public relations strategies (Ciszek, 2015). According to Heath and Waymer (2009, p.197):

Public relations is not only a key element in the effectiveness of activists, but it actually pressed academics to realize how long public relations (even if only by strategy or tactics if not by name) has been practiced.

Historically, the relationship between activism and public relations has been nebulous (Gudkova & Sarikakis (2018)), owing to the dominance of functionalist approaches that view activism as an obstacle for organizations to achieve their goals (Ciszek, 2015). As evidence, Grunig (1989, p. 4) contended that "[a]ctivist groups produce conflict between organizations and their environments, and it's the presence of conflict that creates the need for public relations." In this light, activists can be perceived as an organization's opponent (L'Etang, 2007) while public relations is perceived as the defender of the organization's values (Adi, 2018). Coombs & Holladay (2013) offer a more nuanced view, suggesting activism has commonalities with public relations to support

social movements and other reforms. This relationship can be understood from Holtzhausen's (2013, p. XV) inclusive description of activism:

Activism is resistance in the small things and the big things. Activism means caring for the Other without asking anything in return. Activism means living life meaningfully, consciously, actively, honestly, responsibly, calling things the way you see them, intolerant of practices that marginalize, dehumanize, and discriminate, speaking truth to power. Activism also means continuously learning and gaining knowledge of how society functions. Knowledge remains the most powerful tool in leading a life of activism.

The authors of this study portray activism as actions that promote direct intervention or challenge economic, social, environmental, or political reforms with the aim of social change toward a greater good.

As Kim and Sriramesh (2009) conclude, the intensity of activism is situated within the socio-cultural environment in society, heightening the need for public relations strategies and practices. To broaden community support and galvanize participation in causes, activists need public relations to engage their publics and to serve a media relations function (Rose, 1991). Ciszek (2015) extends this link even further:

...evidence suggests that activists have been implementing public relations for at least 100 years. In fact, a modest body of literature suggests that many of the tactics used by activists are public relations tactics, and their motives can be viewed as public relations strategies (p. 447).

Achieving activist goals can be done either through direct confrontation or seeking regulations (Grunig, 2013). Jackson (1982, p. 215) identified five communication tactics that activists use to achieve their goals: (1) informational activities (interviews and media relations tasks); (2) symbolic activities, such as boycotts; (3) organizing activities (delivering leaflets, networking and conducting meetings); (4) legal activities (petitioning, filing lawsuits or legislation, lobbying, testifying, and involvement in legislative activities); and (5) civil disobedience activities (sit-ins, blocking traffic, and trespassing). In the realm of activism, notions of power are contested and embedded in social structures and cultural norms. For example, the politicization of identity including gender, sexuality and race in the 1960s produced communicative activities previously employed by political organizations, shifting primarily from negotiation toward "building individual power" (O'Brien (2018), p. 48). Activist groups may have different concerns, but all agree on a commitment to enact change (Deegan, 2001).

This research uses the cultural-economic model (CEM) to examine the "conjoined processes" of public relations and activism within macro-social and political contexts (Ciszek, 2017; Curtin & Gaither, 2005). In this sense, Curtin et al. (2016) wrote:

If public relations practice is conceived as embedded in and formative of cultural, social and economic discourses in part by how power shapes their contours, then public relations practice cannot be separated from issues of social justice (p. 45).

The paper applies the cultural-economic model (Ciszek, 2015; Curtin & Gaither, 2005) to illustrate how activism and public relations shared practices to the extent they became synonymous to support women's activists in Kuwait. CEM acknowledges the importance of cultural, political and economic context in the meaning-making process and provides a framework to understand activism as part of public relations (Ciszek, 2015). Han and Zhang (2009) used CEM as a theoretical framework in their study of activist campaigns against Starbucks in China's Forbidden City. Similarly, Gaither and Al-Kandari (2014) used CEM to analyze internal activism of Islamic banking, Curtin (2016) to analyze nonprofit organizations, and Ciszek (2017) for lesbian, gay, bisexual, and transgender activism. This study uses Ciszek's (2015) recommendation to apply the CEM model to study activism and public relations through the case of Kuwait and in an Islamic cultural context.

Gaither & Curtin (2005; 2008) adapted the CEM from the circuit of culture (Du Gay et al., 2013) to demonstrate how interrelated components – called “moments” in the model – dynamically interact with each other to generate meaning. The CEM is comprised of five interrelated moments: (1) *production* – The work of public relations practitioners that includes planning, design, process, resources and technology, (2) *consumption* – How publics make sense of the materials, including various interpretations and modification of the meaning, (3) *identity* – Social understandings of the images created for certain publics, (4) *regulation* – Either formal or informal cultural and social constraints, including infrastructure limitations, type of education system, and laws; and (5) *representation* – The discursive processes embedded in public relations texts predicated on culture, power, and difference (Ciszek, 2015, pp.451–453; Curtin, 2016, p. 21; Curtin & Gaither, 2005, pp. 98–105; Gaither & Curtin, 2008, p. 288). Anderson (2018) noted intent (motivation) is an important element for consideration in the CEM meaning-making process, where the value of any public relations campaign is closely related to a planned objective(s); otherwise, the public relations campaign “becomes simply inserting messages into the public discourse with the hope that something positive will occur” (p.198).

Based on this background, this research proposes three hypotheses:

H1. : Kuwaiti women’s organizations in the 1960s used various public relations strategies as part of their activism to achieve their civil, social and political rights depending on the nature of their members and their societal class.

H2. : Women’s Cultural and Social Society (WCSS) use of activism to gain social rights was more successful than the Arab Women’s Development Society (AWDS), who used activism to gain political rights.

H3. : Women’s activism for social rights is more emancipatory than political rights in a society such as Kuwait where culture, tradition, religion are deeply entwined.

5. Method

This qualitative research explores activism in the context of the women’s movement in Kuwait to foreground activism and public relations in a cross-cultural context. As Martinelli (2014) posits, women have long used public relations to propel social change. Similarly, feminist activists have employed public relations techniques to challenge dominant social norms such as the empowerment of men over women (Bıçakçı & Hürmeriç, 2018). The women’s movement in Kuwait in the 1960s had fractured views regarding the priorities of women issues. At ideological odds were differing attitudes toward women’s social status and political status.

This study encompasses two case studies of Kuwaiti women’s organizations (AWDS & WCSS) in the 1960s. It employs two research methods: (1) textual analysis of historical documents⁴ that include: women’s organizations archives, books and related academic papers of the 1960s women’s movement in Kuwait, relevant uploaded videos, and TV interviews posted online, and (2) a content analysis of newspapers and magazine published in the 60s before and after the establishment of the two organizations. For the second method, some of the study’s authors analyzed Arabic-language newspapers and magazines (*Alrai Alaam*, *Sout Al-khaleej*, *Altalea*, *Alhadaf*, *Kuwait Times*, *Adwa’a Al-Kuwait*, and *Donya Aloroba*) from the June 1962 to June 1963 to capture the period before and after the establishment of the two organizations. The study applies cultural-economic model (CEM) to illustrate how activism and public relations functioned synonymously to catalyze women’s activists in Kuwait, and the effectiveness of activism for social

rights and political rights in an Arab-Islamic society such as Kuwait.

The content analysis of primary sources includes newspapers, magazines, minutes of the organizations’ meetings, conference documents, and leaflets were analyzed covering a period of one year, from June 1962 to June 1963, six months before and after the official establishment of the organizations. Secondary resources, including videos, TV interviews, books, research papers, and dissertations, were also analyzed and covered an extended period of time, from June 1962 into the early seventies, to provide broad context.

All collected data comprised 2353 items. Of that number, those directly related to the study’s objectives, hypotheses, and CEM, were 481 (20 %). The remaining 1872 (80 %), are summarized in the first part of the results section to provide insights into the regulatory environment surrounding Kuwait’s press freedom relative to women’s issues. The summary also offers a sociocultural context of Kuwaiti attitudes toward women in society.

Two coders familiar with the study’s objectives and hypotheses analyzed the 481 items directly related to the research. Their consensus or co-agreement was a requirement for an in-depth analysis. Coders had to agree if an article reflected a CEM’s moment(s) and the type of moment(s) for analysis. In case of a disagreement, a third coder with the same knowledge of CEM and the study was employed. The English translation of Arabic materials was another issue in the coding process. Texts were translated according to their exact wordings and meanings. The two coders, who were Arabic-English bilingual, also had to agree whether the English translation reflected the exact meaning in Arabic. The third coder was then involved to settle disagreement by selecting a translation out of the two translations provided by each coder. This process was intended to generate high reliability. The two coders disagreed 53 (11 %) times when analyzing the 481 items, yielding an intercoder reliability of 89 %.

6. Results and discussion

6.1. Analysis of all gathered items

This section briefly summarizes the 1872 items that did not directly meet study criteria but contribute insights into Kuwaiti press freedom regarding women’s issues and add context to the sociocultural climate in Kuwait regarding women.

Donya Alouroba magazine widely covered woman’s issues from a liberally progressive perspective that often clashed with the predominant tenets of religion and culture. It showed images of women wearing swimming suits and provided articles advocating for women and gender equality. It also portrayed women from different Western countries in progressive roles, contributing to politics and society, a counternarrative to the restrictions women in Kuwait often faced. The magazine suggested women in Kuwait deserved the roles and portrayals inherent in the West, frequently accompanied by large and bold headlines. In one example, the magazine showed Iraqi women demonstrating in joy after the ouster of President Abdul Kareem Qasim. The images demonstrated the prominence of women in the revolution. The newspaper *Alhadaf* heavily addressed women’s political issues and highlighted Kuwaiti women’s involvement in parliamentary elections similar to their male counterparts. It covered issues such as segregation, social empowerment of women, and political participation by women.

Social coverage from and of women complemented political and ideological coverage of issues. For example, an investigative article by *Alhadaf* titled, “Marriage crisis in Kuwait” suggested the conservative, or traditional, way of raising children with confined parental roles contributed to greater marriage problems. The article noted both genders were raised in isolation from each other in social settings and in education, where male and female students were segregated in schools, leading to estrangement of women and cultural patriarchy. Also, *Alhadaf* newspaper highlighted “Celebrating Mother Day,” in which mothers and all women were recognized for their role raising children and working at

⁴ From The Center for Research and Studies on Kuwait and National Library of Kuwait.

home.

While such articles were accommodative of the issues faced by women through a cultural and religious lens, others downplayed press coverage of progressive women and activism. Of the latter, some took a more cynical approach by blaming women for the perceived sinfulness of Kuwaiti society. In one example, a male columnist penned an article titled, “The Immodest Women,” excoriating the behavior of men and women in cinemas as unacceptable. The columnist complained the two genders flirt, exchange laughs and chat, ignoring Islamic and traditional norms. The columnist placed the blame on women for their suggestive dress and for going to cinemas late at night.

Another narrative in the media suggested women needed liberated from sociocultural and religious structures, a deep divide from the dominant discourse suggesting the opposite. This coverage is so distanced from the dominant narrative that one could reach the conclusion the coverage was not Kuwaiti or originated in a more religiously and culturally conservative country. Indeed, the majority of those who ran and operated Kuwaiti media in the 60 s were non-Kuwaiti nationals from Lebanon or Syria, far more liberal countries with standards of living comparable to the West. Female activists seized this counternarrative as an opportunity to exercise press and speech freedom in Kuwait that drastically increased with the establishment of the constitution in 1962. Finally, in the 1960s, socialist and liberal ideologies gained prominence in Kuwaiti and Arab political spheres, unlike the seventies and afterward when tribalism and religious sects dominated the political scene in the country and much of the Arab world.

6.2. Content analysis and CEM

This section provides the analysis of the 481 items fitting criteria related to the research objectives, hypotheses, and CEM. Through its five moments, the (CEM) situates public relations as a process of creating meaning within social, cultural and political contexts, highlighting the relationship between activism and public relations (Curtin & Gaither, 2005). The moments of the model: regulation, production, consumption, identity and representation provide a cultural framework to study women’s activism by suggesting meaning is “created, shaped, modified, and recreated” (Curtin & Gaither, 2007, p. 38). As such, the study addresses a much-needed lacunae in the literature through the case of Kuwait and its 1960 women’s movement (Table 1 and Table 2).

The 1960s were a period of political turmoil in the Middle East. In the early part of the decade, Iraqi leader Abdulkareem Qasem repeatedly claimed Kuwait as part of Iraq, leading to national and regional tensions. With this background, Kuwait established its first Constitutional Council and held its inaugural elections in 1963. Despite a frenetic news cycle, women’s issues and coverage of AWDS and WCSS appeared in many local newspapers and magazines. *Al-Hadaf* newspaper allocated one page and sometimes two pages for articles related to women called *Mujallat Almara wa Tafil* (“Women’s Magazine and Kids”). Most of the articles focused on entertainment and activities related to women. On the other hand, *Sout Alkhaleej*, the first newspaper published after the independence in 1962, allocated one page for women called *Hawae* (Eve) edited by Hidayat Al-Salem. The newspaper served as a voice for women by crossing an invisible line acknowledging contested women’s issues such as political and equal rights. For example, on April 26, 1962 article focused on women in diplomacy. Nouriya Al-Saleh (AWDS’s founder) wrote an August 16 article that same year titled, “Where is the woman in the constitution?” (Al-Saleh, 1962). Similar articles include the September 20, 1962 article “Kuwaiti women between yesterday and today,” and a November 29, 1962 front page article with the headline of “The Minister of Education calls for the establishment of a women’s association” (Sout Al-Khaleej, 1962b). Another headline story in October 1962 (“The Establishment of the First women’s Association in Kuwait”) covered the launch of AWDS with a picture of Nouriya Al-Sadani (Photo 1) (Sout Al-Khaleej, 1962a).

Sout Al-Khaleej quickly carved a reputation as supportive of women’s

Table 1

A comparative table of similarities and differences between WCSS and AWDS.

Items	WCSS 1963	AWDS 1962
<i>Membership socioeconomic class</i>	• Merchant-class women • Restricted to educated women	• Middle-class women • Open to all women regardless of socioeconomic class or education level
<i>Organizational objectives of each organization and strategies</i>	• Serving community and society • Societal Welfare (charitable) • Spreading education and increasing literacy among women • Improving women’s public communication skills • Educating women about health • Providing solutions to family affairs • Supporting Arab political causes about independence • Defending women’s rights • Raising women’s awareness of social issues • Spreading awareness about women and youth involvement in volunteering	• Professional development • Societal modernization • Raising women’s social status • Obtaining women’s political rights • Fostering gender equality • Initiating social, health, scientific and charitable projects • Increasing women’s influence civil and political rights • Highlighting the role of Kuwaiti women in sports, culture, science and social development • Establishing mutual cooperation with other Arab women’s organization • Highlighting role of women in family and social life
<i>Communication channels</i>	• Use of media • Hosting foreign dignitaries and public diplomacy • Visual communication – images and videos	• Word-of-mouth • Use of media • Visual communication through means of images and videos • Hosting foreign dignitaries and public diplomacy
<i>Public relations tactics</i>	• Volunteering • Workshops and classroom activities • Press conferences • Media content and leaflets • In-organization support services such as nurseries • Media articles and appearances • Use of role models and authority appeal • Equality appeal	• Press conferences • Media content and leaflets • Media articles and appearances • Public speeches • Hosting well-known and academic women • Holding international exhibitions
<i>Target publics</i>	• Educated women • Government officials • General public	• General public • Local and international politicians • Women in general • Political • Social
<i>Areas of emphasis</i>	• Recreational • Social empowerment of women • Educational • Media	• Marxist approach • Direct and confrontational approach
<i>Policy in communication with other social entities</i>	• Elitist approach • Diplomatic in government affairs • Respecting and appraising religion and tradition • Avoidance of confrontations • Indirectly addressed women rights • Increasing awareness of women • Internal approach emphasizing on local targets	• Seeking social change or changing status-quo • Respecting religion and tradition • External approach that can also target Arab countries

Table 2

Outcomes WCSS and AWDS in relation to CEM moments.

Items	WCSS	AWDS
Regulation	- Arab and Muslim social and cultural women activism - An elitist approach and ideology	- Originally non-Arab; Liberal and socialist global activism - A middle-class approach and ideology
Production & consumption	- Traditional media, such as newspapers and magazines - Public relations activities such as press conferences - Interpersonal PR models that connect to influential people in authority - Focus on education and social women issues in media coverage	- Traditional media, such as newspapers and magazines - Progressive public relations activities such as lobbying and grassroots campaigning - Direct connection with the public in general - Focus on political and constitutional rights
Identity and representation	- Kuwaiti female audience - Influential men in authority and government - Targeting culturally restrictive norms - Volunteerism and charitable work	- Kuwaiti and Arab female audience; - Pan-Arabic - Influential male politicians - Word-of-mouth and visual communication - Targeting the constitutional and legal system - International reach

**Photo 2.** Coverage of the AWDS launch in *Donya Aloroba*.

omission.

6.3. Moment of regulation

Even though the 1962 constitution gave equal rights to men and women, such equality proved illusory. Women continued to formally and informally struggle with cultural, traditional, religious, and political norms to obtain their equal rights. Such obstacles forced women to confront cultural norms that accorded them subordinate status. Women had to exert significant effort to shatter stereotypes and negative image framing – or their exclusion altogether – to claim their constitutional rights through education, social participations, and legal advocacy.

6.3.1. Feminism and liberalism

The term “feminist” has a negative connotation in Arab-Islamic society because it is considered as related to Western ideology. Golley (2004, p. 521) explained that many Arabs and Muslims see “feminism as an illegal immigrant and an alien import to the Arab world and, as such, [it] is not relevant to the people and their culture.” Woman’s rights in an Arabic-Islamic society such as Kuwait are mainly connected to Western’s women ideology under the aegis of liberalism. To distance themselves from negative perception, female activists do not distinguish themselves from Muslims by illustrating respect for the values of Islam. Through this strategy, women connote they are an integral part of Kuwaiti society. This was apparent with the WCSS adding the phrase “cultural & social” to the organization’s name because the words “cultural” and “social” implied the organization’s activities and conduct adhered to Arab and Islamic cultural and societal identity. AWDS used the word “renaissance” (*Alnahdha*), to associate with renaissance as a movement of resistance countering culturally patriarchal practices often rooted in colonialism. It reflected women who wanted cultural sovereignty in a similar fashion to the sweeping independence of many Arab countries during 1950–1970s, which sought autonomy from Great Britain, France and the other European nations viewed as tyrannical imperial powers.

6.3.2. Religion and culture

Islam is omnipresent in Arab countries such as Kuwait, inextricably threaded through cultural and behavioral practices. It factors into every facet of life, providing a dominant cultural context that women’s activists skillfully negotiated. Their challenge was to embody Islamic norms through the narrow strictures of acceptable engagement with Islam. Since most of the activists were not wearing *Hijab* (veils) and some of them were against wearing *Abayah* (cloak-the Islamic dress covering the entire body), they had to present themselves as pro-Islam and respectful of Islamic and Arabic culture. For instance, when WCSS President Mrs. Lulwa Al-Qatami addressed a crowd regarding gender

**Photo 1.** The coverage of AWDS establishment in *Sout Al-Khaleej*.

rights, and it became a primary public venue for women to express themselves and their societal concerns.

AWDS took a leadership role publishing articles that addressed women’s political and equality issues before and after the formal establishment of the organization. *Al-Talea* newspaper reserved a page for women called *Ma’a Hawaa* (With Eve). It published various articles by and about women, including a critique suggesting the two women’s organizations should become devoted to women gathering and socializing, not as places to exchange pressing women’s social and cultural issues. (Al-Talea, 1963). The Arab political magazine *Donya Aloroba* similarly published articles about women’s ideas and movements in the early 1960s. A January 20, 1963 issue used pictures and a full page to cover the AWDS launch (Photo 2) (*Donya Aloroba*, 1963).

Notably, other influential magazines and newspapers in Kuwait excluded women and their nascent organizations, including influential daily newspapers such as *Alrai Alam* and *Kuwait Times*. These publications wrote out of existence women’s activism through a politic of

segregation, people in the crowd began chanting “*Lulwa Adawat Allah*” – “Allah’s enemy” (Black Box, 2020). Thus, women’s activists needed a well-planned strategy to navigate cultural norms between “wrong” and “right” practices of Islam by showing their publics that they do practice Islam and pray like other Muslims.

6.3.3. Merchant-class and middle-class

There are four primary class stratifications in Kuwait: At the top is the ruling family followed by merchants, the middle class, and at the bottom are mainly the migrant workers, the latter of whom were non-Kuwaiti individuals who were not permitted to participate in Kuwaiti politics or societal organizations which were restricted only to Kuwaitis (Ghabra, 1997; Longva, 2005). Based on previous research, the two women’s organizations were divided into two class groups: WCSS for the merchant class and AWDS for middle-class women. Many women in the WCSS had husbands or relatives in high-ranking governmental and official positions resulting in informal pathways to communicate with government entities about their social demands. They avoided confrontations with the government and were more likely to sidestep women’s political rights and shift their narrative more toward awareness of women’s social status and education. Conversely, with its strong middle-class representation, AWDS initiated a more forceful approach demanding women’s political rights. AWDS communicated directly with publics at a grassroots level and politicians such as members of parliament who had previously expressed support for women’s rights. In other words, WCSS was diplomatic in its government affairs while AWDS took a far more blunt and vigorous grassroots approach addressing women’s issues.

6.4. Moments of production and consumption

In the parlance of the CEM, the moment of production is the site where public relations practitioners produce materials – the tactics of public relations (Curtin & Gaither, 2005).

In Kuwait, both women’s organizations used public relations tactics as part of their awareness campaigns including entertainment events, conferences, writing petitions, publishing articles in local newspapers, and appearing in international news media. Of the two organizations, AWDS more actively focused on local print media through media relations centering on women’s political and constitutional rights. Both organizations employed many of Jackson’s (1982) five communication tactics such as: (1) informational activities through media interviews and negotiating allocation of space in print newspapers and magazines, (2) employing tactics ranging from conferences and leaflets, (3) initiating meetings for media coverage and photo opportunities with a wide range of publics, including local government officials; popular Arab singers, actors and actresses; and Arab leaders such as Gamal Abdel Nasser, former president of Egypt; and (4) pursuing legal recourse for women. In particular, AWDS more aggressively lobbied the National Assembly and engaged with the government.

6.4.1. AWDS from CEM perspective

In the initial minutes of its first board meeting in early 1963, AWDS outlined a key objective to host visiting female personalities to Kuwait to engage them on a range of issues, including women’s status and activities. AWDS members also suggested holding exhibitions abroad to publicize Kuwaiti women’s activities and contributions to society. These ideas gave the initial impression the association sought to convey the importance of Kuwaiti women externally (AWDS, 1973). Thus from the beginning, AWDS’s strategy coalesced around woman’s rights, most notably in the political realm and toward equality with men. Mrs. Nouriya Al-Sadani, who launched AWDS and was the first woman to file a complaint to the National Assembly for women to vote, said, “The political rights of women are the most prominent thing I have done in my life for the history of the nation” (Harb, 2006). She affirmed this notion in her first speech as president of AWDS:

We cannot treat women’s problems, or liberate them by writing papers, or kill their rights in research, but we need to raise the status of women and make them equal to men so that they can stand with them in all fields of life. It hurts us to see the half of society (women) languishing in homes under the pressure of stony minds that have been robbed by time, circumstances, customs and traditions. We make a great effort to make her believe in what we believe in and guide her to the right path, the path of light (AWDS, 1973, p. 28)

Both organizations used the 1962 Constitution as a shield for woman’s rights. Even though multiple articles in the constitution recognized women’s rights and gave them equal rights to men, they were not enacted due to either religious or cultural barriers. Women’s activists appointed legal experts to help them educate the Kuwaiti society, especially women, about women’s rights, not only politically, but also about their legal status in the society. Both organizations appealed to international audiences to engender support for women, with AWDS outpacing WCSS in such efforts.

6.4.2. WCSS from CEM perspective

As daughters of merchants with liberal visions for women in society and strong relations with the royal family, WCSS’s members had an advantage to move forward with their ambitious goals. At the same time, this advantage convinced WCSS to adopt what can be considered a moderate long-term strategy centered on women’s awareness and education. WCSS offered special classes for uneducated women to provide them with the education previously unattainable, drawing inspiration from the Arabic proverb “A women’s education is equivalent to the education of an entire generation.” Such an approach highlighted the importance of education to increase the status of women (Alfarsi, 2013). Mrs. Al-Qatami emphasized this point at a 1994 conference where she said education brought an opportunity for women to weaken and ultimately remove some of the social obstacles that had obstructed her own path (Al-Qatami, 1994, p. 15).

In CEM, the moment of consumption is how publics make use of a cultural artifact, such as a campaign issue or product, in their everyday lives and form new meanings around it as a consequence of its use (du Gay et al., 2013). As a result, public relations practitioners must consider that their efforts might not be consumed the way originally intended, which means consumers are active participants in the creation and co-creation of cultural meanings. Increasingly, production and consumption are conceptualized as two parts of an interrelated process where meanings are contested and negotiated (Curtin & Gaither, 2005). In this case, WCSS and AWDS were jointly determined to strategically produce materials that could be consumed through a positive interpretation of woman’s legitimate missing rights. For example, both organizations tried to distance themselves from Western liberalism as it was viewed as anti-Islam, instead opting to skillfully align women’s rights with Islamic rules while supporting Arab movements.

6.5. Moments of identity and representation

Arab women were a critical public for both organizations. At a local level, the organizations sought to reframe the restrictive image of women as housekeepers with limited basic rights alternatively to women who could actively contribute to Kuwait’s development, renaissance and progress. Kuwaiti women’s activists widely traveled to Arab countries, inviting Arab women from across the Middle East to share their perspectives about the status of women in society and seek suggestions to improve their standing. As part of these tours, the women met with Arab leaders, including the President of Egypt (Photo 3).

6.5.1. A woman’s place is not at home

The dominant cultural narrative promulgated by the patriarchal Kuwaiti culture was captured in the popular saying a “Woman’s place is at home.” Disrupting such a narrative was essential for both



Photo 3. President Gamal Abdel Nasser receiving Kuwaiti women lead by Mrs. Lulwa Al-Qatami in 1963.

organizations. Many males – and even women – believed in this axiom backed by perceived religious claims and from tradition. WCSS started a public relations campaign specifically to challenge this firm cultural assumption by educating women. AWDS directed its public relations efforts toward political rights for women. When the two organizations were established in the 1960s, illiteracy women among women was high. AWDS based its strategy around word-of-mouth and visual communication while leveraging national resources to prioritize women's literacy as a benchmark for their rights. Mrs. Al-Qatami, who was nominated for a Nobel Prize in 2005, explained the importance of awareness for their movement:

This movement with its declared goals as a 'social cultural' focuses on the importance of raising awareness to highlight what women and society suffer from and find solutions for them (Al-Qatami, 1994, p. 15).

According to Al-Qatami, eradicating women's literacy was important to boost the role and status of women in society. She opined that literacy should not be limited to learning to read, but also on acquiring skills and experience necessary to participate in the public sphere and advance women's rights in Kuwaiti society (Al-Qatami, 1994). Prior to WCSS, educated women, especially those who went abroad to obtain a degree, individually practiced activism through media relations such as columns or opinion pieces in print media. When *Al-Beitha* magazine launched in the 1940s, women's activists advocated for recognition in the magazine through freelance articles. This effort led to the magazine to reserve a space '*Rukn al-mar'a*' ("Women's Corner") for monthly women's articles, and for women to write feature articles for other print media as freelancers or guest editors. Eventually these modest steps spawned a women's magazine called *Usrati* (My Family) in 1965 (Tirca, 2020).

Al-Qatami (2013) situated WCSS strategically in society, delicately respecting religion, culture and tradition by recognizing the absence of women's social, civil and political rights. In an environment where female writers and newspaper editors were reluctant to publish bylined articles by women and women were likened as injurious to Kuwaiti society, WCSS adopted a strategy to bring an "awareness and shallowness of culture, so, one of our duties was to fight that lesion and demolish it" (Al-Qatami, 2013, p. 92). The first step of this strategy was to include the word 'culture' in the organization's title because:

We realized since the beginning that we were in a long battle with ignorance and primitive thinking, and that we had to face the obstacles that would destroy our dreams and hope, we prepared ourselves to encounter everything that would come our way (Al-Qatami, 2013, p. 92).

Thus, the WCSS took advantage of the country's educational development to further women's status without fracturing Kuwaiti values (Al-Qatami, 2013). As Al-Qatami explicated:

We put up a plan for awareness and nothing else as a spin for our work, the basic system of the society was that the purpose of building

it up in the first place is to grant its members a chance to practice cultural, social and sport activities (Al-Qatami, 2013, pp. 93–94).

From the early beginnings of the WCSS, members had precise goals to achieve, and they set their carefully orchestrated strategic plan to achieve them. Most of those members were educated, making it easier to achieve the preeminent goal of the organization to highlight 'awareness' for women's issues to benefit Kuwaiti society (Al-Qatami, 2013, p. 94). One of WCSS's awareness objectives is what Mrs. Al-Qatami called "the icon of education work," which held women can gain a stronger role in society through education (Aldabbas, 2021). The other challenging task for WCSS was to change societal resistance to women's volunteerism. Charitable work by women was not viewed as beneficent to society but as an excuse for women to seek entertainment or get out of their houses (Al-Qatami, 2013). Owing to such cultural constructs, women were pejoratively called "the Velvet community" in Kuwait (Al-Qatami, 2013, p. 94) (Photo 4.).

Activists generated new representations of femininity in Kuwait from weak and passive to an iron-willed woman who refused second-class status. To reposition women accordingly, activists attended male-oriented events, traveled abroad to attend either conferences or to participate in humanitarian aid, stood in solidarity with Arab movements through the participation of political demonstrations, and rejected traditional Islamic outerwear such as the *Hijab* or wearing the *Abaya*. These activities were captured through photos published in either the local newspapers or the organizations' publications.

7. Conclusion

This study relates activism to public relations in Kuwait and the Middle East, geographic locations largely understudied in extant scholarship. By prioritizing activism of Kuwaiti women, this study highlights public relations efforts and communications modes that are often ignored or accorded secondary status in Western activism efforts. Second, the translation of non-English materials reveals the communicative practices deeply embedded in cultural patterns. These practices illustrate how language, as a verbal communication modality, is intrinsically intertwined in the cultural milieu connected to public relations. Third, applying the cultural-economic model to Kuwait demonstrates the versatility and generalizability of the model. Such studies extend CEM's reach and applicability to cross-cultural settings.

The research examined how women's organizations in Kuwait in the 1960s under a male-dominated society with high illiteracy among women used public relations tools as part of their activism to challenge norms woven through a patriarchal society. The study demonstrates the need for acknowledging societal values, traditions, culture and politics as entwined within the concept of activism to achieve intended goals. In Kuwait, women illustrated that building support for their causes from males and politicians did not equate to achieving a goal. Indeed, one of the chief obstacles the two organizations faced was through illiterate women who were either uneducated or unconvinced their role in the



Photo 4. WCSS's special classes for uneducated women to increase literacy among women.

society could be anything other than that prescribed through Islamic religion, culture or tradition. The research suggests the two women's organizations had similar goals but different strategies. While the AWDS priority centered on political rights, WCSS concerned itself with empowerment and educating women. The cultural-economic model illuminated the different public relations strategies as part organizational activism. And while there were some similar goals, the two organizations had different priorities. The political aims of AWDS led to its eventual dissolution and ban in the 1980s while the educational priorities of WCSS have impelled its continued existence.

Despite tensions between the activism strategies of AWDS and WCSS, Kuwaiti women did elevate their status. There is evidence, however, the women's gains in Kuwait are far less substantial than if the two organization had worked more collaboratively rather than complementing and occasionally co-opting each other. At the core of such tensions were differing priorities. AWDS founder Nouriya Al-Sadani contended that if the organizations had shared priorities, they would have met their goals in the 1970s, far sooner than when political rights for women bloomed in 2003. Where the two organizations shared a common approach was through their use of public relations. Both used similar tactics in their activism campaigns, including publishing articles in the local press, publishing research papers and books, giving lectures and seminars, organizing conferences, community service, international visits, receiving delegates, and lobbying. Many of these tools were effective as part of awareness efforts (see Photo 5). Education was the connecting tissue for activists to embrace change and help them unite under one umbrella of women's rights.

In Arab-Islamic societies, especially in Gulf States like Kuwait, meanings and connotations of terms such as feminism and liberalism, religion, middle-class and merchant-class, education and rights, and constitutional might have dramatically different interpretations than those in the West. These two cases illustrate the strategic use of public relations tools through activism in Arab culture, suggesting effectiveness of public relations in Arab-Islamic states cannot be separated from culture and religion. Results show female activists used public relations to elevate their status in society and to achieve their missing rights as stated in the constitution while modifying the negative perception of women in society. Thus, all three hypotheses were supported: H1, that both organizations (AWDS and WCSS) used public relations communication strategies in the 1960s as part of their activism to achieve their civil, social and political rights; H2, that WCSS more effectively used activism to gain social rights than AWDS, whose emphasis on activism for political rights led to its ban in the 1980s. An arguable point is the political rights women gained in 2003 were owed to AWDS's efforts from the 1960–1970s. Critics of such a viewpoint might also undermine the role of both organizations and suggest the pressure for women's rights came more from the liberation of Kuwait, American pressure, and the government's willingness to fully embrace women and their contributions during the invasion of Kuwait by Iraq in 1990. Finally, the results also supported H3, that women's activism for social rights was more effective in an Arab-Islamic context than for political rights in a society such as Kuwait where culture and religion are inextricably linked with societal norms. Indeed, Rizzo (2005) discusses that even for Arab secular women's rights activists, there is a need to incorporate an Islamic frame of reference to convince society of women's rights and issues: "Where the overwhelming majority of the citizens are Muslim, activists working for women's rights need not only demonstrate that they identify strongly with Islamic tenets, but also need to justify to Kuwaiti society that women having a voice in political life is also Islamic" (p. 33).

The qualitative analysis of both organizations showed WCSS had a standing goal for women's political rights through priorities to educate women as part of its 'awareness' (Taweyya) public relations campaign. To this end, WCSS prepared women to play an important societal role to presage future political rights while AWDS' goals were to fully realize women's missing constitutional rights, particularly in the political



Photo 5. Part of WCSS' awareness campaign through lectures, seminars and conferences.

realm. This paper illustrates the potency of effective of public relations tactics and strategies as part of activism to challenge the sociopolitical and cultural regulations that stereotype women and their role in an Arab Muslim nation like Kuwait.

Both organizations distanced their activism from treatments associated with Western liberal feminism by recasting their activism through and around Islamic and Arab culture. Applying CEM helped identify factors that women face in a society deeply entrenched in cultural constructs, Islamic religion and Arab tradition to gain basic rights. Moreover, this study contributes to understanding women's movements in the Middle East, more specifically in the Gulf region where public relations and activism can jointly spur societal change and at least partially negate the barriers women face in society.

As with any social science study, this research has limitations. Kuwait is a small, culturally and religiously conservative country. The findings of the study might be generalizable to other Arab and Middle Eastern nations where Islam predominates, but the relative weight accorded to the trio of culture, tradition and societal norms will undoubtedly vary, as could the accrued relationship between meanings of activism and public relations. For researchers outside the Pan-Arab world, this research models an approach and framework that captures influence of culture and religion in activism, particularly as it relates to women's rights.

Declaration of Competing Interest

None.

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